

7. Exact decoding as a structural case study

OUTPUT *Abstract.* We use exact two-ended palindrome decoding to show what a mirror-cost result means operationally. The decoder preserves character validity independently of any language-model score. A POS-shape feasibility gate rejects partial word sequences that cannot extend to a member of a finite allowed tag-pattern language. It is sound for that finite predicate: an invalid prefix or suffix projection cannot become valid through the permitted future extensions.

CRITIQUE POS shape is not syntax. Tag ambiguity, local agreement failures, attachment, and semantics remain unconstrained. Calling accepted strings grammatical would turn a safe pruning result into an unsupported linguistic claim.

REVISION APPLIED Use the term *finite POS-shape language*; prove only predicate soundness; state that the gate measures structural viability rather than grammar or meaning.